NORTHSTAR DIGITAL

EMPLOYEE HANDBOOK & WORKPLACE POLICIES

Synthetic training document — Northstar Digital is a fictional company. All policies, dates, and contact details in this handbook are invented for learning and RAG practice. They are not real legal or employment advice.

1. Company overview

Northstar Digital is a fictional software and digital services company founded in 2021. Its main office is listed as 14 Meridian Way, Bristol, United Kingdom. The company provides workflow automation, data services, and customer support software to small and medium-sized businesses.

The company's stated mission is to make everyday business processes simpler, safer, and easier to measure. Its fictional workforce includes engineering, customer success, operations, sales, and design teams.

2. Working hours and attendance

Standard working hours are Monday to Friday, 9:00 a.m. to 5:00 p.m. in the employee's agreed local time zone, with a one-hour unpaid lunch break. Employees are expected to complete 35 working hours per week.

Teams may agree on flexible start and finish times between 7:00 a.m. and 7:00 p.m., provided core collaboration hours of 10:00 a.m. to 3:00 p.m. are covered. Employees should notify their manager as early as possible if they will be late or absent.

Attendance is recorded through the company's fictional WorkTrack portal. Employees who cannot access the portal should email people@northstar.example.

3. Annual leave and other time off

Full-time employees receive 25 days of paid annual leave per calendar year, excluding public holidays observed in their agreed work location. Part-time leave is calculated proportionally.

Leave requests should be submitted through WorkTrack at least 10 working days before the first requested day. A manager normally responds within three working days. Approval depends on team coverage and business needs; employees should not book non-refundable travel before approval.

Employees may take up to five paid sick days per calendar year under this fictional policy. For an absence lasting more than two consecutive working days, the employee should inform their manager and People Operations. Emergency and legally protected leave are handled according to applicable local law.

4. Remote and hybrid work

Remote work is permitted when the employee's role can be performed securely outside the office and the arrangement has been approved by their manager. Some roles may require occasional in-person attendance for planning, training, or client meetings.

Employees working remotely must maintain a private workspace, use company-approved devices, protect confidential information from being viewed by others, and remain reachable during agreed core collaboration hours.

Employees must obtain written approval from People Operations before working from a country different from their contracted work location. Tax, immigration, insurance, and data-protection requirements may restrict cross-border work.

5. Code of conduct and respectful workplace

Employees are expected to communicate respectfully, act honestly, protect customer interests, and avoid conflicts of interest. Harassment, discrimination, bullying, retaliation, threats, and deliberate misuse of company resources are prohibited.

Concerns may be raised with a manager or People Operations at people@northstar.example. If the concern involves the employee's manager, the employee may contact the fictional Ethics Lead at ethics@northstar.example.

Reports will be handled as discreetly as reasonably possible. Retaliation against someone who raises a concern in good faith or participates in an investigation is prohibited.

6. Data security and acceptable use

Employees must use multi-factor authentication on company accounts, create unique passwords, lock their screens when away, and install security updates promptly. Passwords and authentication codes must never be shared.

Customer data, employee records, credentials, source code, and internal financial information are confidential unless explicitly approved for public release. Confidential files must be stored only in approved company systems.

Employees must report suspected phishing, lost devices, accidental disclosure, or unauthorised access to security@northstar.example as soon as possible. The report should include what happened, when it was noticed, and which systems may be affected.

Company devices and accounts are provided primarily for work. Limited personal use is permitted if it is lawful, does not interfere with work, and does not create security or reputational risks.

7. Expenses and equipment

Reasonable, pre-approved business expenses may be reimbursed. Employees should obtain manager approval before spending more than £100 on a single item or commitment.

Expense claims must be submitted within 30 calendar days and include an itemised receipt, business purpose, date, amount, and currency. Finance aims to review complete claims within 10 working days.

Company laptops and accessories remain company property. Employees must take reasonable care of equipment and report loss, theft, or damage to IT Support at it-support@northstar.example within 24 hours.

8. Learning and performance

Managers should hold a one-to-one meeting with each employee at least once every month. Formal performance conversations take place twice a year, in April and October.

Employees may request up to £300 per calendar year for role-related learning, including courses, books, or professional events. Requests require manager approval before purchase and must explain how the learning supports the employee's role.

9. Support contacts

People Operations: people@northstar.example — leave, attendance, workplace concerns, and policy questions.

IT Support: it-support@northstar.example — devices, software access, and equipment incidents.

Security Team: security@northstar.example — phishing, lost devices, suspected breaches, and data-security questions.

Ethics Lead: ethics@northstar.example — confidential escalation when a concern involves an employee's manager.

Finance Team: finance@northstar.example — expense claims and reimbursement questions.

10. Document control

Document owner: People Operations. Version: 1.0. Effective date: 1 January 2026. Review date: 1 January 2027.

This handbook is deliberately short and self-contained so it can be used to practise PDF loading, text extraction, chunking, embedding, vector storage, retrieval, and grounded question answering.